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Invitational Education: Theory, Research and Practice

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ABSTRACT *Invitational Theory argues that learning is enhanced when learners are positively encouraged or 'invited' into the educational experience. Arising from perceptual and self-concept theory, Invitational Pedagogy is constructed on four principles: respect for people, trust, optimism and intentionality, and upon five pillars: people, places, policies, programmes and processes. Its main contributions address the psychogeography and the constructive alignment of learning environments and the training of teachers and counsellors. Key research methods include the invitational/disinvitational index and the 5-P relay.*

KEY WORDS: Invitational Education, W.W. Purkey, affective learning environments

Introduction: Invitational Thinking

Swami Vivekananda wrote, "Education is the manifestation of the perfection already in Humans . . . the only duty of the teacher . . . is to remove all obstructions from the way . . . That is our duty, to clear the way" (Vivekananda, 1894, in Vivekananda, 1989, Vol. 4, p. 358). In higher educational practice, all many learners need is an opportunity; they are self-motivated, driven by internal fire and self-belief in their personal goals. Others need help. They must feel persuaded that the time is right, the place is right, the people are supportive and that learning is good. If not, they may remain inactive, frozen and embarrassed until the mental obstacles that inhibit them are removed. Removing obstacles to engagement with education, this is the purpose of a learning invitation.

An invitation is a signal that requests companionship or consideration. Invitational Theory is an applied field that seeks, intentionally, to modify the sum of the (often non-verbal) signals and signs that affect human self-belief and to create from these a system of educational practice. Invitational Theory has roots in John Dewey's 'democratic ethos' (Dewey & Ratner, 1939), but it is constructed upon foundations in perceptual and self-concept theory (Purkey & Stanley, 1991). Its goal is positive intentionality; the

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constructive alignment of the messages transmitted by, and contained within, any given learning environment (Biggs, 2003). It aims to expunge the negatives that inhibit learners.

This paper introduces Invitational Theory as a framework that provides the ways and means of researching the geographies of learning places and especially the 'affectiveness' of learning environments, which is the way a learning environment makes you feel. It provides a way of recognizing why certain learning processes, such as fieldwork, successfully engage learners (Haigh & Gold, 1993; Meijles & Van Hoven, 2010). It provides a methodology for the intentional construction of learning invitations and illustrations of how the impact of these invitations may be evaluated. It introduces Invitational Theory as a new lens for research into Geographical Higher Education and indicates where it already intersects with the discipline. Finally, it contrasts Invitational Pedagogy with Appreciative Inquiry (AI), an apparently similar but mainly unrelated approach from the Positive Psychology stable and from the Action Research toolkit.

Invitational Research and Practice

Invitational Theory constructs itself on four principles: respect for people and their differences, trust expressed through cooperation and a sense of community, optimism about the untapped potential contained within each learner and intentionality, which means taking those steps needed to create each learning invitation and to address it to each learner (Purkey, 1991a; Purkey & Novak, 2008). In Missouri, Burns (2007) found that better performing schools display more invitational qualities and, qualitatively, that respect and trust are the qualities teachers feel most essential for creating an effective organization, while their leaders emphasized only 'trust'. In South Africa, Steyn (2003) used semi-structured interviews and focus groups to study the effect of introducing Invitational Practice into an award-winning Afrikaans medium school. She found that the keywords for the success of this cultural change were respect, trust, optimism and intentionality, with establishing trust through leadership as its central component (Covey, 2006).

Intentionality is the keyword of Invitational Theory. Many invitational learning environments are created through good practice unconsciously and many disappear the same way. The aim of Invitational Education is to understand what it takes to create and sustain invitational environments. This analysis is guided by Purkey's (1999; Table 1) five 'Powerful Ps' of invitational practice: people, places, policies, programmes and processes, whose invitational qualities must be woven into the culture of a learning situation or institution. At the institutional level, Fink (1992) admitted a sixth P–political will power. Collectively, these ally closely with three of Fink's (2008) familiar 'four fundamental tasks of teaching': 'designing effective learning experiences', 'interacting with learners' and 'supportive course management' but not so much with 'course content'.

Purkey and Novak (1996) expressed the 'P's as five principles: (1) people are able, valuable, responsible and should be treated as such; (2) educating should be a cooperative activity; (3) a Gandhian ideal, that there is no separation between the means and the end product; (4) that the role of the teacher is to help learners realize their untapped potential and (5) this can best be realized by places, policies, programmes and processes that are designed to invite development and people who intentionally invite engagement. They argued that when the 'P's evoke positive feelings in a learner, that person is said to be 'invited'. Equally, when they evoke negative feelings, that learner is 'disinvited'.

Table 1. Five powerful 'P's of Invitational Education (after Purkey, 1999)

P1. People	Instructors and learners work together as a family, with courtesy and respect, to build long-term relationships and to manage stress and conflict
P2. Places	Places exude a positive, cared for and caring atmosphere, clean, sustainability conscious, welcoming and including, so that those who use them feel some sense of ownership and of belonging
P3. Policies	Policy and policy-making respect people and their needs, provide an environment of mutual support and a learning community ethos
P4. Programmes	All programmes emphasize community engagement and service, wellness, well-being and the enrichment of all involved especially the learner and their self-development
P5. Processes	All management and operational processes function in inclusive, democratic ways that support the self-developing ethos of the learning community

Invitational educational research concerns the construction of the positive attributes of learning situations. For example, in a traditional Geography subject context, Haigh (2008) engaged in research that tries to reconnect learners with their sense of place, one of those five 'P's, by inviting them to analyse the way in which the different places interact with their emotional states. The context of this work is an upper-level Geography course, 'The Ethical Geographer', which explores ethics, emotional intelligence and empathy, environment and future employment (Boyd *et al.,* 2008; Mayer & Salovey, 1993). Haigh used fieldwork as a vehicle for exploring the feelings induced by different places and invited learners to reflect, creatively, on the way that different places affect the way they feel (Tuan, 2004). Building on precedents in Situationism and Psychogeography (Debord, 1969; Coverley, 2006), student teams go out to map parts of their local habitat in terms of their emotional impact. Responding to an intercultural understanding agenda, Haigh's method for this assessment is borrowed from India's Sāmkhya Philosophy (Harzer, 2005). Sāmkhya conceives the universe as the product of consciousness and among its core concepts are the three Gunas. In Sāmkhya, these Gunas, or 'Strands of Nature', are said to control and colour everything—much as dots of just three primary colours make up each colour photograph. The three Gunas are Sattva, which is light, pure, reflective and serene, Rajas which is active, creative/destructive and dynamic, and Tamas, which is inert, veiled and obstructing (Jacobsen, 1999). Learners, in teams and through discussion, create a map of their local environment using the Gunas as their palette. Later, individually, they are asked to consider what their group considered made one particular place inviting and another disinviting and why? They are then asked to consider how their personal habitat, often the campus or their college room, could be made into a more inviting place for either (Sattvic) reflection or (Rajasic) creativity and interaction. Research into the effectiveness of this intervention involved the analysis of end-of-semester questionnaires, the contents of team project report posters and individual reflective learning diaries. Participants reported enjoying the novelty of this exercise and, in some cases, that it initiated new creative thinking about the places they inhabit and the way they organize their lives (Haigh, 2008). Of course, Geographers may be allowed a special interest in 'Place' but all five 'Powerful Ps' and their interactions are legitimate targets for Geographical research.

Table 2. Four invitational levels (after Purkey & Schmidt 1990, pp. 21–30)

Intentionally disinviting	Demotivation is a powerful tool of control and it is widely used in academic contexts. Its 'toxic assets' include activities designed to discourage, demean, defeat, demoralize, disempower and discriminate against. Its manifestations include the constructive use of overloading, stress and assessment to promote insecurity, a focus on shortcomings and sanctions and all activities intended to undermine the self-concept and confidence of learners and teachers alike
Unintentionally disinviting	Inadvertent demotivation is a common outcome of target-driven systems that are often well-meant but obsessed with policies and procedures. Negative and discouraging messages are transmitted through control systems that display a lack of confidence in those involved, through systems that emphasize 'the stick', that create stress through overloading and that display disregard, disrespect, distrust, insincerity, pessimism and a lack of concern for those participating in the learning process
Unintentionally inviting	A motivational learning environment has appeared by chance. It is positive, supportive and collegial. It demonstrates respect, trust, optimism, self-belief, etc. in its human interactions. The only problem is that this outcome is a side effect, it is 'just the way it is', and there is no conscious effort or design in either its creation or preservation. It is thus vulnerable to inconsistencies and retrogression through inappropriate decision-making by those who, quite simply, do not comprehend what they manage and hence are incapable of either its maintenance or development
Intentionally inviting	A motivational learning environment is created by conscious attention to the four principles and five 'powerful Ps' of Invitational Education. Its ambience is optimistic, respectful and trustworthy. It is empowering, engaging and energizing. Its participants are enthusiastic, genuine, open and imbued with self-belief. Its managers are supportive, nurturing, democratic, ethical encouraging and self-aware. Its places are caring and cared for. Its true intention is to encourage every participant to make the most of their own potentials and this is understood by all

Invitational research concerns the construction of motivational learning situations and the detection and elimination of demotivational learning situations, both at the personal and the collective levels (Foote, 2010). These situations fall into four categories, which are summarized on Table 2, and which provide a framework. Together, these four categories provide a framework for research and analysis. Where used to explore the outcomes of learning interventions and to develop strategies for improving learning environments, this structure is often applied in the form of the inviting/disinviting index (IDI), a quantitative tool used to evaluate behavioural impulses in educational contexts. The IDI questionnaire is based on four subscales: inviting to self (self-confidence), inviting to others (e.g. congratulating others on success), disinviting to self (self-inhibiting) and disinviting to others (negativity, blame games, threats) (Schmidt *et al.* 1998). Table 3 displays these four levels expanded into questionnaire items. The example comes from a study that explores the relationship between invitational behaviour on the part of learners and various motivational and achievement indexes (Valiante & Pajare, 1999).

Table 3. IDI questionnaire subscales (after Valiante & Pajare, 1999) (with actual numbering of the question on the questionnaire)

Subscale: Inviting self
8. I am quick to recognize my own value
11. I plan time for enjoyable activities that I can do on my own
13. I congratulate myself on my successes
18. I forgive myself for my misbehaviour and mistakes
20. I am impressed with my own abilities
Subscale: Inviting to others
1. I like to include other people in enjoyable activities
4. I congratulate others on their successes
6. I forgive others for their misbehaviour and mistakes
9. I am impressed with the abilities of other people
15. I am quick to recognize the value of other people
Subscale: Disinviting self
2. I am hard on myself when I think I've done something wrong
5. I neglect my own needs
7. It affects me for a long time when I think I've done something stupid
10. I am overly critical of myself
14. I don't pay attention to my own needs
Subscale: Disinviting to others
3. I criticize others when I think it is needed
12. I neglect the needs of other people
16. I tell other people when I think they have done something stupid
17. I do not pay much attention to other people's needs
19. I blame others when I think they did something wrong

Here, statistical analysis found high positive invitational IDI scores to have an indirect correlation with achievement through correlations with motivation and self-regulatory practice (Valiante & Pajare, 1999). The study also found a direct negative relationship between self-invitational behaviour and age; younger learners scoring higher than older learners, an observation echoed in many other studies (Valiante & Pajare, 1999). However, in contrast to earlier research, this study found significant gender differences between male and female (K6–K8) learners, with the latter being more invitational and less disinvitational to others. This moved Valiante and Pajare (1999) to link their findings to the engendered 'ethic of caring theories' of Gilligan (1982). Elsewhere, an interview study of the factors that affected the success of female academics in Mathematics and Technology found that while self-belief was nurtured by a range of family, academic and work-related influences, the pivot was often "an invitation received from an influential person, often during a critical time, who helped them develop their beliefs about their capabilities" (Pajare & Zeldin, 1999, p. 60). Burns (2007) found no significant difference between the invitational qualities of male and female educational leaders.

Intersects Between Invitational Education and Geography

To date, Invitational Theory has had small impact on research in Geographical Higher Education, impinging mainly through teacher training work designed to create safer and more learner-supportive micro-geographies in secondary schools (Stanley *et al.,* 2004). However, it has greater influence on professional fields such as healthcare; hence,

MacDonnell and Andrews (2006) focused on invitational theory's exploration of the means of creating safe environments in sexual healthcare contexts using the perspectives of Feminist Geography.

Invitational Theory is also promoted as one of the ways of helping teachers achieve empathy and deal more effectively with human relationships, not least in cross-cultural contexts (Alberts *et al.*, 2010; Patterson & Purkey, 1993; Ivers *et al.,* 2008). Alverno College's (1995) innovative teacher training curriculum, which has been influential in Geography, used Purkey and Novak's (1996) methods to develop affective teaching that focuses on the positive development of each student's self-concept through the development of learning practices that invite active learner participation (cf. Haigh, 1996; Jenkins, 1996). Invitational Theory stresses three qualities in teacher development: empathy, non-possessive warmth and genuineness (Patterson & Purkey, 1993). This is why it has also been employed to deal with the ethical educational challenges created by the commercialization of educational institutes (Purkey & Novak, 1998) and as a best practice approach to the peer observation of teaching (Osborne & Purkey, 1995; Blackmore, 2005).

Using Invitational Theory in Pedagogic Research

From a Geographer's point of view, some of the most interesting applications of Invitational Theory relate to the wider problems of constructive alignment between the classroom message and the management ethos of institutions (cf. Biggs, 2003). Here, Invitational Theory has a major role to play (Bluestein, 2001). Typically, Invitational Theory's five 'P's and four levels (Tables 1 and 2) provide the framework for the generation of research hypotheses, which are explored by methods typical of qualitative and quantitative social science research (e.g. Steyn, 2006, phenomenology; Steyn, 2003—interviews; Asbill & Gonzalez, 2000—questionnaires and statistical analysis). However, in this institutional context, the most distinctive Invitational research tool is the 60-item *Revised Invitational Schools Survey*, which is also applicable to HE levels (Smith & Barnard, 2004). This standard questionnaire evaluates the influence of the five 'P's and the results from its application identify 'place', followed by 'people', as the leading factors governing the perception that an institution 'invites learning'. Smith and Barnard (2004) also suggested that the strength of such perceptions increases with respondent's age and possibly maturity.

Another distinctive and useful Invitational research methodology is the P5-Relay, which is a 'World Café' style exercise used to brainstorm the qualities and effectiveness of any particular educational situation. Five desks are set aside, one for each of the 'Powerful Ps' and a recorder set at the table. Next, groups of those who are stakeholders in the target environment move from table to table identifying the degree to that their current circumstances are inviting or disinviting. Once this is accomplished, the groups move on toward identifying solutions (Stanley, 2006; for method see Purkey, 1991b).

AI vs. Invitational Education: Comparison and Critique

Presently, when Invitational Education is introduced, mention is often made of 'Appreciative Inquiry'. AI is another member of the Positive Psychology stable but there seems to be little direct connection between it and Invitational Education or its literature

(Seel, 2008). AI is an approach to the management of organizational change while Invitational Educational Theory emerges from perceptual psychology and educational practice. However, it may be worth exploring the intersections of these two approaches.

Invitational practice is about creating a courteous and supportive educational habitat in which everyone flourishes. It aims to enable stakeholders to achieve their full potential through participation in a shared vision that is guided by optimism and finds diversity normal (Burns, 2007). It is often applied to the reform of educational organizations. By contrast, AI is all about the reform of organizations. It begins with the assumption that all organizations are alive with creative, constructive possibilities and it aims to apply a paradigm of conscious good that stimulates the coevolution of people and their organizations (Cooperrider, 1990). AI is a form of Social Constructionism, which locates meaning, value and action in social communications in interaction. Like Invitational Education, it is also a branch of Action Research. However, the AI key is the art of asking constructive, unconditionally positive, questions that help an organization understand and anticipate its potential. Where Invitational Education employs vehicles like the 5-P relay to help guide the reform of Educational systems, AI offers its more spiritual 4-D cycle, where the Ds are Discovery, Dream, Design and Destiny and inquiry derives from 'affirmative topic choice', where that topic is something that brings life to the organization. While Invitational Education emphasizes quiet affirmation, the slightly more wild-eyed AI stresses enthusiasm (cf. Bunch, 1982). In the language of Sāmkhya, Invitational Education is more Sattvic and AI more Rajassic (Haigh, 2008). Its practice, however, is grounded in the recognition of an organization's 'positive core'. It builds from positive examples in an organization's past, where 'history' is largely absent from Invitational Education thought. Its application involves the realization of a collective dream through new structures based on a new way of knowing, a new 'art of the possible' that AI discourses should generate. Its vehicle is the creation of a 'Positive Change Network' of transformative cooperation, and its success evolves from making organizational change that seems inspired rather than mechanical (Cooperrider *et al.,* 2003; Piderit *et al.,* 2007). AI is beginning to seep into pedagogic research (and hopefully in due course—practice), especially those parts that relate to administration, leadership and school improvement, but there is not yet a huge literature (Yballe & O'Connor, 2000, Willoughby & Tosey, 2007, Calabresse *et al.*, 2008).

Meanwhile, Invitational Theory is criticized for being apolitical, saccharine and romanticized (cf. Giroux, 1983). Although it is popular with classroom practitioners, critics argue that it inherits the individualist ethic of humanistic psychology and prefers social etiquette and self-concept to the discourses of ideology and power. It needs to be more than an apology for the *status quo* (Maclaren, 1986). By contrast, Shuayb *et al.* (2009) advised that AI only works if it is supported by deep commitment from all participants, especially leaders, and that it is unsuited for research into areas where participants have little experience or where there are problematic social issues—since it requires a new way of being that is confounded by negative attitudes (Elliot, 1999). This need for the collective positive is not shared by Invitational Education. Certainly, Invitational Education may be used to frame research across whole organisations but it is equally applicable to individual learning situations. More importantly, Invitational Education was designed specifically for work in negative environments and among those who are disempowered, alienated and disengaged.

Conclusion

Invitational Education is an approach to affective education that is constructed on the belief that encouragement and self-belief are critical factors in promoting better learning and that learning thrives more effectively in an environment that is supportive and caring. Its core concept is the 'Learning Invitation'—a courteous request to engage with education. However, the approach is a pedagogic contribution to a larger array of strategies that emphasize the social construction of self-esteem and enthusiasm (Ellis, 2001), including Positive Psychology (Boniwell, 2006) and AI (Cooperrider & Whitney, 2005), all of which involve positive thinking, participative and transformative action research and which tackle self-destructive tendencies in organizational culture.

For many years, Geography departments have, more or less subconsciously, deployed fieldwork programmes as their own particular learning invitation as their prominence at recruitment events bears witness. However, many Geography courses that employ opt-in inquiry-based or problem-based learning strategies have similar aspects (Pawson *et al.* 2006). Invitational Theory's main benefit for Geography is that it provides a framework that allows these learning invitations to be made intentionally—by design rather than by chance. In addition, it offers a range of research methods that may be adapted for the holistic evaluation of learning environments and the assessment of the effectiveness of any particular learning invitation. In science, a good hypothesis is said to be that which encourages the creation of new and useful questions. In this sense, Invitational Theory is good because it encourages researchers to address new questions and provides researchers with questions that need to be answered, such as what affects the engagement and disengagement of learners with different aspects of their learning?

Currently, while its heyday may be past, the front line in Invitational Education research involves attempts to substantiate its effectiveness claims. It is one thing to boost 'self-belief' or create intentionally invitational environments but far harder to measure its impact on learning outcomes beyond an intuition that "the harder you try the more likely you are to succeed" (Riner, 2003, p. 42). However, Invitational Education's holistic approach to the whole educational environment chimes in very closely with the concepts of constructive alignment (Biggs, 2003). It contains some simple, easily applied, research tools including the IDI, 5-P relay and the Revised Invitational Schools Survey questionnaire, which are useful for the diagnosis and transformation of learning environments. Its theoretical base is easily grasped and easily accessed, with much information available freely on the Web. Finally, the fact that it emphasizes 'place' and the micro-geographies of learning and teaching, makes it deserving of attention from those who would meld geography and educational practice.

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